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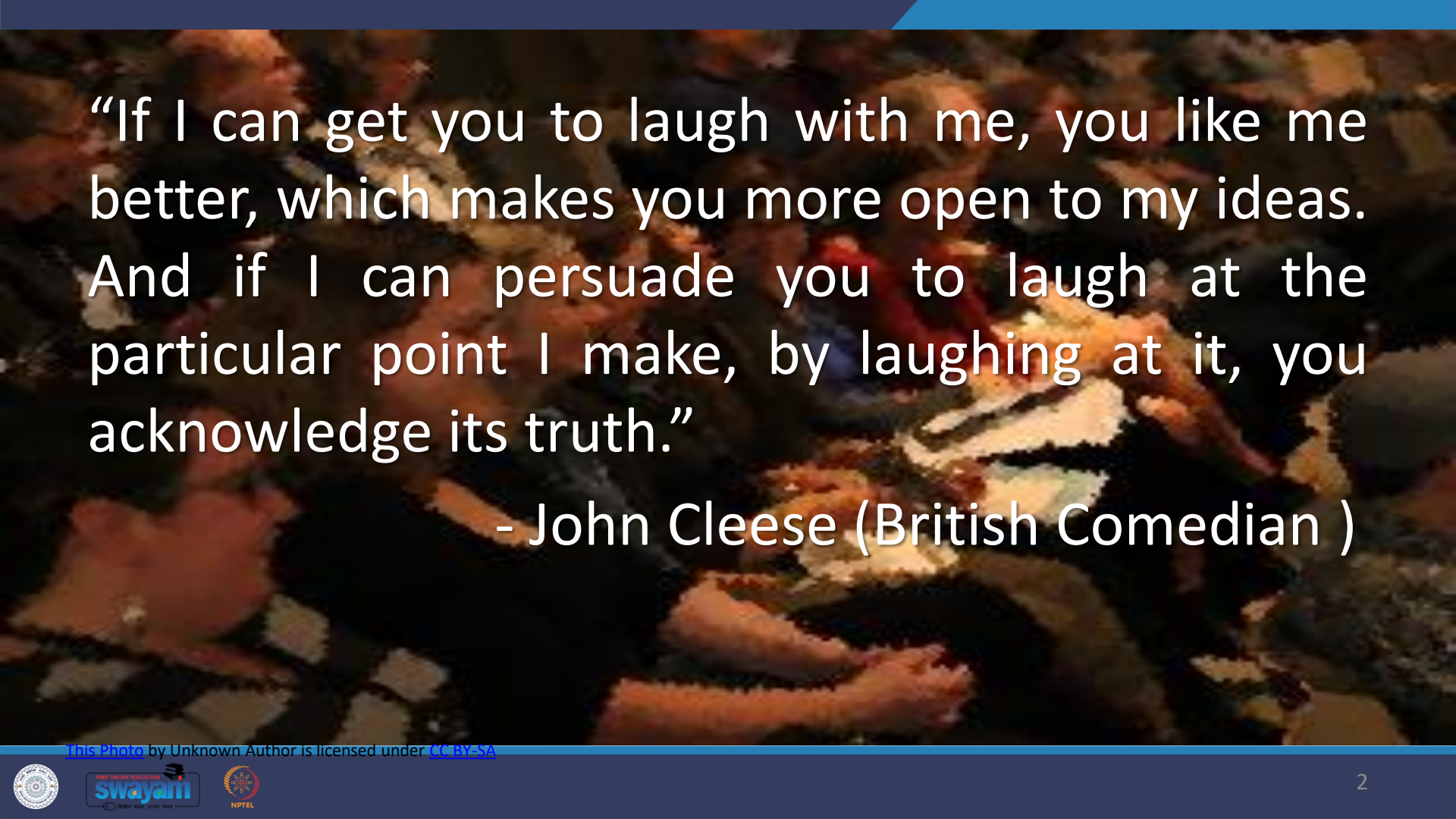
Public Speaking

Lecture 36: Use of Humour in Speeches

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“If I can get you to laugh with me, you like me better, which makes you more open to my ideas. And if I can persuade you to laugh at the particular point I make, by laughing at it, you acknowledge its truth.”

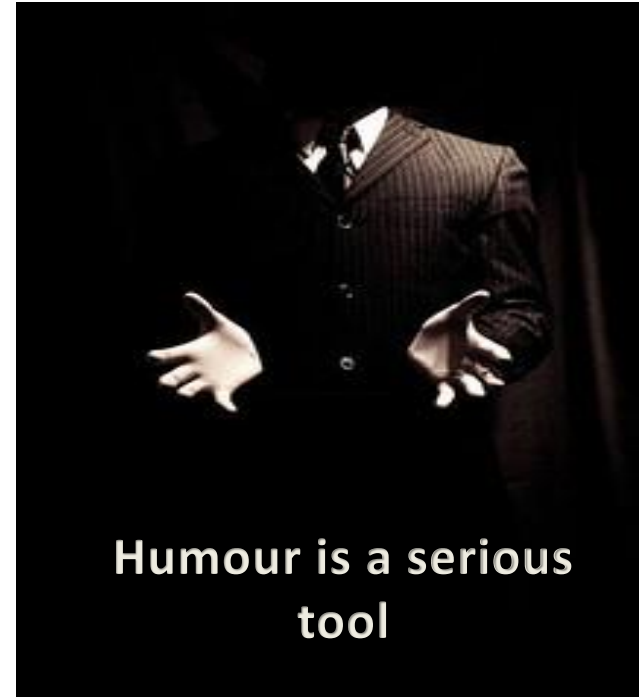
- John Cleese (British Comedian)

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What is Humour?

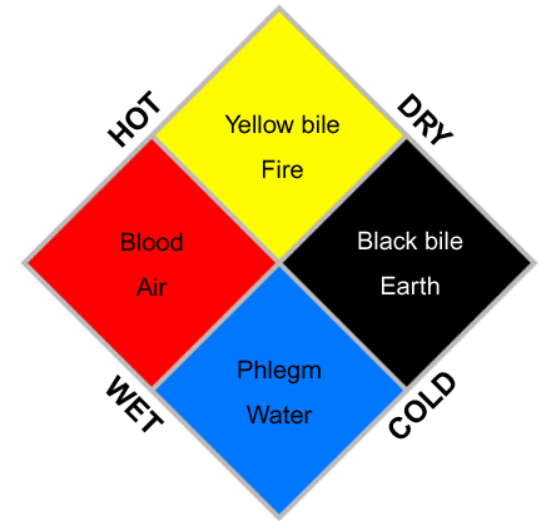
- ❑ According to Encyclopaedia Britannica, humour is a mode of “communication in which the stimulus produces amusement.”
- ❑ As described in one of the previous lectures, humour is a double-edged sword when it comes to public speaking.



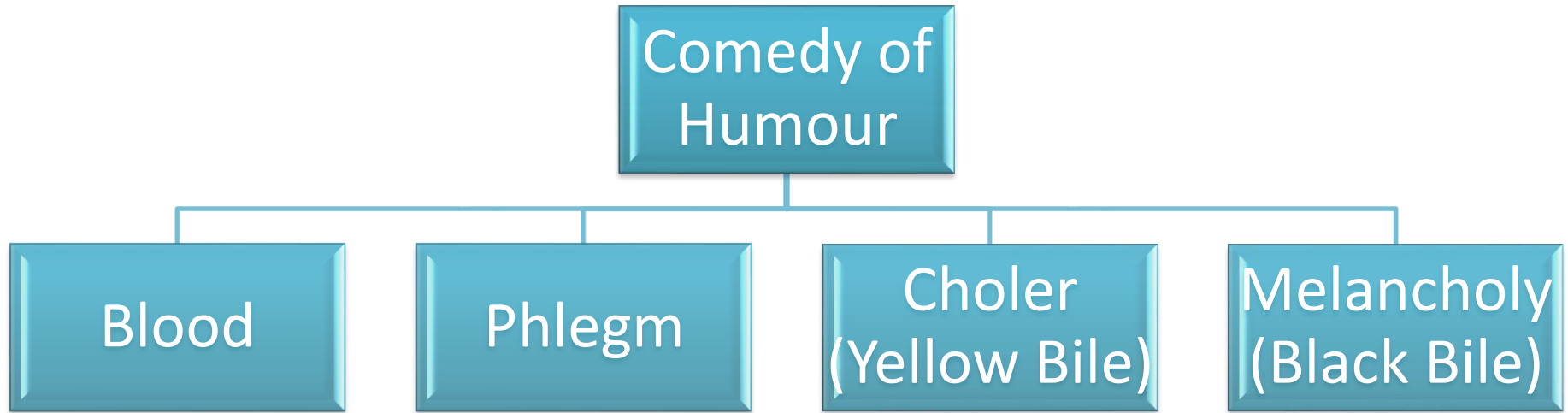
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Comedy of Humour

- ❑ In literature, Ben Jonson's comedy of humours was a dramatic genre in the late 16th century.
- ❑ It is derived from the Latin word 'humor' meaning 'liquid'.
- ❑ According to Renaissance physiological theory, the human body held a balance of four liquids or humours.
- ❑ These humours determined the physical attributes as well as the character of an individual.

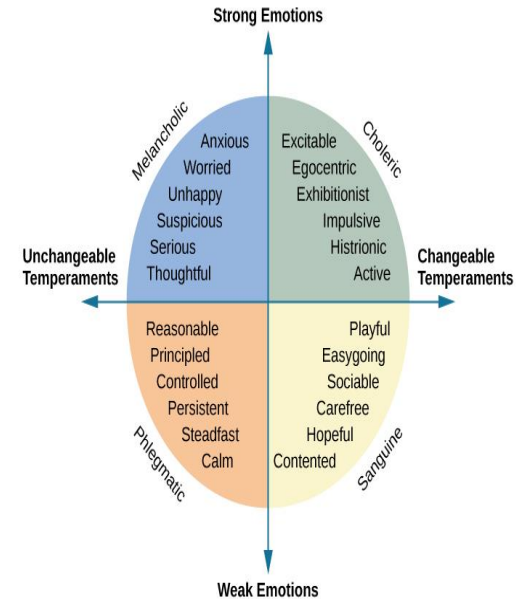


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The senses of humour were held to be the four primary fluids—blood, phlegm, choler (or yellow bile), and melancholy (or black bile)—whose “temperament” (mixture) was held to determine both a person’s physical condition and type of character. An imbalance of one or another humour in temperament was said to produce four kinds of disposition, whose names have survived the underlying theory: sanguine (from the Latin “sanguis,” blood), phlegmatic, choleric, and melancholic. (Abrams et al. 51)



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Literary Example of Humour

In Shakespeare's play *As You Like It*, Rosalind in Act IV Scene I, says,
“Come, woo me, woo me; for now I am in a holiday humour and like enough to consent.”

Later in the same act, she exercises her wit and humour and says,

“Say “a day” without the “ever.” No, no, Orlando, men are April when they woo, December when they wed. Maids are May when they are maids, but the sky changes when they are wives. I will be more jealous of thee than a Barbary cock- pigeon over his hen, more clamorous than a parrot against rain, more new-fangled than an ape, more giddy in my desires than a monkey. I will weep for nothing, like Diana in the fountain, and I will do that when you are disposed to be merry. I will laugh like a hyena, and that when thou art inclined to sleep.” (Shakespeare)



Use of Humour in Public Speaking

- “Humor is a broad, multifaceted term that represents anything that people say or do that other perceive as funny and tends to make them laugh, as well as the mental processes that go into both creating and perceiving such an amusing stimulus, and also the emotional response of mirth involved in the enjoyment of it.” (Martin et al. 16)
- It is a fundamentally social phenomenon and forms an integral part of all types of public speaking, including speeches and presentations.



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Why is Humour Important?

- ☐ It is very important to know the difference between being efficient and being effective.
- ☐ One can be efficient with gadgets, but with humans, one needs to be effective as they have emotions.
- ☐ In order to be effective, one needs to include humour in one's speech.
- ☐ Using humour in your message can get people to stop- hammer time- and pay attention. Humour also makes your message more memorable and improves long-term memory retention. (Tarvin)

Humour Techniques

Gregory Peart, in his book *You Can Be Funny And Make People Laugh*, talks about several techniques that can be very effective in anchoring the interest of the audience. Some of the techniques are as follows:

- ☐ Be Anyone But Literal Larry (Nobody really enjoys a literary joke)
- ☐ Laugh at yourself first.
- ☐ The Humor's in the Details. (Just Not Too Many Okay?)
- ☐ Paint Better with Metaphors.

- ☐ Add Some flavour to Your Opinion
Soup.
- ☐ Look for Contrasts.
- ☐ Sneak in Some Sarcasm.
- ☐ Add Hypotheticals to Your Opinions.
- ☐ Ask the Fun Questions. (Peart)

Styles of Humour

Affiliative

Self-enhancing

Aggressive

Self-defeating

Styles of Humour

Psychologist Rod A. Martin identified four broad styles of humour:

- **Affiliative humour** is employed to enhance one's relationships with others.
- **Self-enhancing humour** allows one to find mirth in difficult situations.
- **Aggressive humour** comprises sarcasm, teasing, ridicule, etc.
- **Self-defeating humour** consists of sabotaging oneself for the mere approval of others. (Abadi)

Psychological Perspective of Humour

- ❑ The humour process can be divided into four essential components:
 - ✓ A social context
 - ✓ A cognitive-perceptual process
 - ✓ An emotional response and
 - ✓ The vocal-behavioural expression of laughter

Use of Humour

- ✓ Proper usage of humour can have tremendous benefits:
- ☐ It helps in creating a bond with the audience
- ☐ A speaker who uses balanced humour automatically becomes likeable.
- ☐ It anchors the audience.
- ☐ The stimulus generated by humour is healthy.
- ☐ Humour is capable of providing emotional relief to the audience.

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- ❑ Well-placed humour can be a relief from serious talks.
- ❑ If rightly timed and occasioned, humour has lasting impacts.
- ❑ Laughter contributes to cognitive functions and impacts memory.
- ❑ Complexity of any topic can be put to rest with humour.



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Producing and receiving humour

- An individual needs to mentally process information coming from the environment or from memory, playing with ideas, words, or actions in a creative way, thereby generating a witty verbal utterance or a comical.
- Nonverbal action that is perceived by others to be funny.
- Reception of humour is reflected through our eyes and ears, process the meaning of this information, and appraise it as non-serious, playful, and humorous.



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"She's as headstrong as an **allegory**".

He is the very **pineapple** of politeness!" Pineapple?

"Our watch, sir, has **comprehended** two **auspicious** persons."

Cultivate- Captivate, Sad to meet you.

"Three cheers for our queer old dean!" (rather than "dear old queen," which is a reference to Queen Victoria)

Chipping the flannel on TV- flipping the channel on TV

Examples of Humour

- ❖ “My advice to you is to get married: If you find a good wife, you’ll be happy; if not, you’ll become a philosopher.” —Socrates
- ❖ “Common sense is like deodorant. The people who need it most never use it.” —Anonymous
- ❖ “We must both, I’m afraid, recognise that as we grow older, we become like old cars- more and more repairs and replacements are necessary.” – C.S. Lewis
- ❖ “Never put off till tomorrow what you can do the day after tomorrow just as well.” —Mark Twain

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- ❖ “Anyone who lives within their means suffers from a lack of imagination.” —Oscar Wilde
- ❖ I would never die for my beliefs because I might be wrong.
-Bertrand Russell
- ❖ The years between 50 and 70 are the hardest. You are always being asked to do things and yet you are not decrepit enough to turn them down. – T.S. Eliot
- ❖ To be without some of the things you want is an indispensable part of happiness. -Bertrand Russell

Things to remember about Humour

- ✓ Jokes and humour are culturally-oriented.
- ✓ Using humour may, at times, backfire.
- ✓ Humour in speech doesn't necessarily be hilarious.
- ✓ Surprise is an element of humour.
- ✓ “Smiles and chuckles are better than belly laughs”. (Richard Dawis)

What to Avoid while using Humour?

- ❖ Too complicated jokes
- ❖ Too many jokes/humour
- ❖ Don't announce that a joke is coming; just deliver it.
- ❖ No usage of controversial topics and unacceptable language.
- ❖ Avoid using humour based on ethnic, religious, gender and other human deformities.

*“Laughter is the sun that
drives winter from the human face.”
-Victor Hugo*

Thank You

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